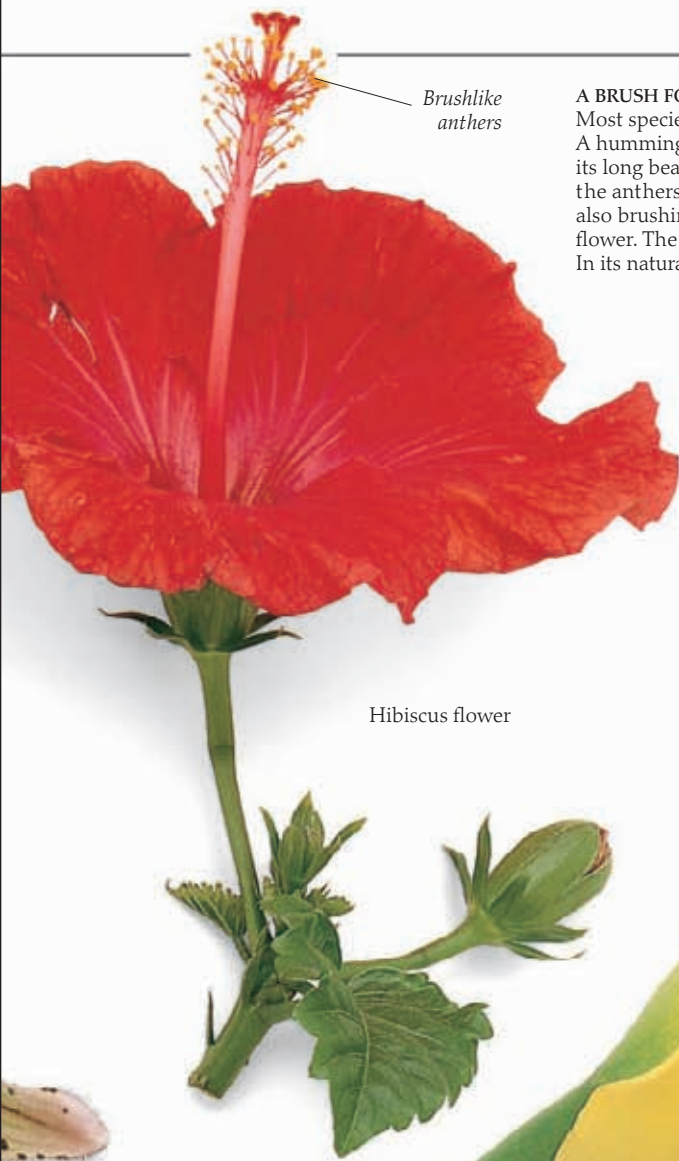




Brushlike
anthers

Hibiscus flower

A BRUSH FOR BIRDS

Most species of hibiscus are pollinated by hummingbirds. A hummingbird hovers in front of the flower and inserts its long beak deep inside to reach the nectar. As it feeds, the anthers brush pollen on to its head, while the stigma, also brushing its head, collects pollen from another flower. The flower shown here is in an upright position. In its natural state it would normally be horizontal.

BIZARRE BEAUTY

The yellow calla lily is pollinated by insects called fungus gnats. Its separate male and female flowers grow on a spadix, or central spike, and are enveloped by a bright yellow leaflike hood called a spathe. The insects, carrying pollen from the male flowers of other plants, crawl to the base of the spathe, where they become trapped by downward-pointing hairs. As they move around, they pollinate the female flowers. The hairs then wither, and as the insects crawl out they are dusted with pollen from the mature male flowers, ready to move on to the next plant.

Bright yellow spathe
(leaflike hood) envelops
the flowers on the spadix,
or central spike



Yellow
calla lily

POSSUM POLLINATION

The Australian honey possum is a tiny marsupial that lives entirely on the pollen and nectar of flowers like this banksia. It collects its unusual food with its long snout and brushlike tongue. Aside from the possum, the only other mammals to pollinate flowers are rodents and bats.



Translucent,
windowlike
cells let
in light

Trapped flies try
to escape by flying
up toward the
light and become
covered with pollen

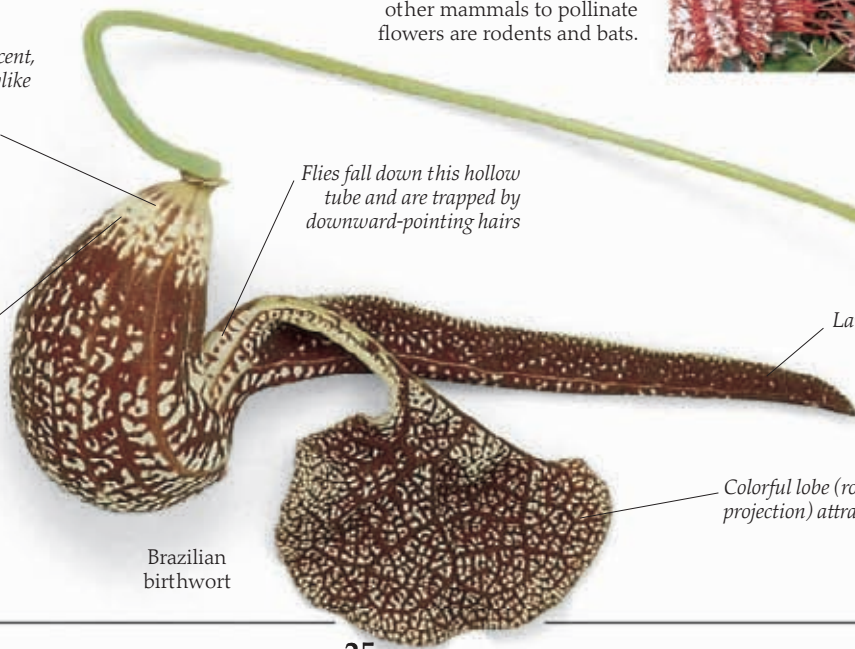
Flies fall down this hollow
tube and are trapped by
downward-pointing hairs

Landing
flap

Colorful lobe (rounded
projection) attracts flies

TAKING PRISONERS

This weirdly shaped flower is produced by a South American creeper. It lures flies by its smell of rotting fish. The flies enter the flower and are imprisoned within it overnight. When the flower begins to wither, the flies—now covered in pollen—can escape.



Brazilian
birthwort